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THE BEST SERIES EVER

India started well under Sourav, winning the ODI series 3–2 against South Africa in March 2000. But soon afterwards cricket plummeted to a low in the wake of the match-fixing scandal. The credibility of the game had been compromised and I found the revelations about matches being thrown for money distasteful and disgusting. The whole thing was repulsive and what was seriously worrying was that fans had started to lose faith and the integrity of our sport was in doubt. We desperately needed to bring credibility back to the game and we hoped that we could do so in the course of playing the Australians at home in a much-anticipated Test series in February–March 2001. It would allow fans to move away from the sordid tales of corruption and focus on the real thing: quality Test cricket.

At the time, Steve Waugh's Australian team were hammering opposition teams both at home and away. They had won fifteen Test matches in a row when they landed in India. In Glenn McGrath, Jason Gillespie, Damien Fleming, Michael Kasprowicz and Shane Warne they had a bowling line-up capable of taking wickets in all conditions. The batting was also exceptional, with Matthew Hayden, Michael Slater, Justin Langer, the Waugh twins, Ricky Ponting and Adam Gilchrist all in good form.

A few months before the Australia series my family had relocated from Sahitya Sahawas to our new haven, an apartment at La Mer Residency in Mumbai's Bandra West, a move to which I contributed very little, I have to confess. It was Anjali who organized everything and